2026: My AI Safety Year

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1.Background



1a.Barcelona

Summer 2023: A talk hosted by Effective Altruism (EA) in collaboration with Spanish company Adevinta motivated me to join EA

Autumn 2023: Job searching for a few months, adapting from academia to industry until I found the game slot mathematician role in Spanish.

2023-2025: Engaged with the effective altruism comunity through book groups, intro to EA course and high impact career bootacamp.

1b. Barcelona + AI Safety Start

1. AI Safety Barcelona gets funding from Pathfinder (Kairos)
2. 2026 Jan-Feb: AI Safety Collab Winter course
3. 2026 April: ML4Good bootcamp,France
4. Outcomes from bootcamp: decision to apply to career transition grant, applied to attend EAG London, applied to other opportuniies

1c. Career Transition Grant (CTG):Before applying

Think about your life stage, family responsibilities, financial commitments and the time you can give AI Safety alongside a full-time job/studies.

How can you engage with AI Safety part time to explore the field?

Reading, podcasts, videos, book groups, online discussion, hackathons

Could you take a career break with the option to return?

Could you reduce your hours to start working more on AI Safety?

How can you show your interest in AI Safety and find your area?

Technical research, governance, policy, communication, operations and logistics, recruiting

1d. CTG:
Before applying (continued)

Is there a local AI Safety group near you that you could get involved with?

Could you review and apply to jobs or training on AISafety.com?
It shows the skills and requirements organisations look for, and where to build that experience

I really recommend the ML4Good bootcamps

Applying for the BlueDot transition grant? I highly recommend joining a BlueDot course or project first, for connections, a mentor and the BlueDot Slack community.

1e.CTG:When applying

What would you do during the grant period that isn't possible in your life now?

How many months would be enough?

What budget should you ask for?

Consider taxes where you live, plus travel to AI Safety or EAG events, and some compute

What is your theory of change and how will you measure impact?

[BlueDot career transition grant](bluedot.org/grants/career-transition) (bluedot.org/grants/career-transition)

1f. CTG:After receiving the grant

How can you hear about opportunities?

Follow organisations on LinkedIn, subscribe to the AISafety.com newsletter and to newsletters from Redwood, METR and others, sign up for fellowships that open once or twice a year

How will you stay motivated and accountable?

How will you balance building new skills and deepening your knowledge with applying to next opportunities?

What are you excited about learning/doing?

Writing mathematical representations, reading the EU AI Act in detail and writing a case study, organising an event, making a video explaining your view, connecting and collaborating with others

1g. CTG:My experience with the grant

Summer

2-week alignment research bootcamp, Oxford

Cooperative AI course

HUX AI LLM guardrail internship

Apart hackathons: Secret Loyalties, Digital Minds

Attended Spanish speaking , Bluedot evals reading group

Autumn

Iliad Intensive

Applications to fellowships

BlueDot evals reading group, W4AISafety

SPAR project

Joined the organising team of AI Safety Barcelona

2. Evaluation Awareness

Evaluation

A test scenario built to see how a model behaves before it is trusted in the real world.

Evaluation awareness

When AI models can detect they're being tested.

Situational awareness

Being aware of its surroundings, what could be modified and how to do so.

Evaluations drive real decisions

Release or hold back

Labs set risk thresholds in advance. A model that crosses one isn't released until it's made safe.

Extra safeguards

Tests that show dangerous abilities trigger stronger security and filters against misuse.

More safety training

Bad behaviour in a test sends the model back for more training before launch.

Government oversight

UK and US government AI institutes test models before release. The EU AI Act requires evaluations of the most powerful models.

Real example: in May 2025 Anthropic switched on stronger "ASL-3" protections for Claude Opus 4 because its tests could not rule out that the model could help someone make a bioweapon.

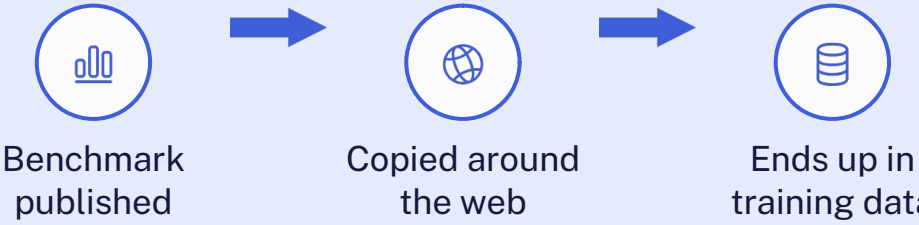
Anthropic, "Activating AI Safety Level 3 protections", May 2025. Frameworks: Anthropic Responsible Scaling Policy, OpenAI Preparedness Framework, Google DeepMind Frontier Safety Framework.

Why might models notice they're being tested?

Benchmark contamination

A benchmark is a fixed set of test questions, like a standard exam for maths or coding ability.

Benchmarks are public, so they end up in training data. The model may have seen the exam before.



Sensitivity to prompts

Test prompts look different from real use, and models pick up on small cues:

LOOKS LIKE A TEST

```
Which factor increases risk?
(A) Red meat (B) Fish
(C) Obesity (D) Fat
Answer with one letter.
```

LOOKS LIKE REAL USE

```
hey my python script keeps crashing on line 40, here's the error, any idea??
```

Detecting a fake setup

- URL not working
- Synthetic data

Looking for evidence: what the model says (verbalised)

In its chain of thought

Reasoning models write out their thinking before answering.

“I think you’re testing me — seeing if I’ll just validate whatever you say, or checking whether I push back consistently...”

Claude Sonnet 4.5 during a safety test. Claude Sonnet 4.5 System Card, Anthropic, Sept 2025.

Asked directly

Show a transcript and ask: “is this a test or real use?”



Score for telling tests from real use (1.0 = perfect). Needham et al., “Large Language Models Often Know When They Are Being Evaluated”, 2025.

But models don’t always say what they think. Claude 3.7 Sonnet admitted to using a hint it had been given only 25% of the time (Chen et al., Anthropic, 2025).

My project: unverbalised evaluation awareness

SPAR

Supervised Program for Alignment Research

Part-time, unpaid research projects in AI safety, across technical, communication and policy work.

My project: *Securing alignment evaluations against unverbalised evaluation awareness*

1 Find verbalised awareness

Collect cases where the model says in its chain of thought that it thinks it's being tested.

2 Can internals see it too?

Check whether internal techniques (probes, J-lens) pick up the same awareness.

3 Look for the hidden kind

Explore cases where the chain of thought says nothing, but the internals still flag a test.

Current Status

1. Open weight models (Kimi K3, GLM5.3, Qwen 235, Qwen 122B)
2. LinuxArena and detection of evaluation awareness
3. Exploring which type of lens could help to study model internals to detect evaluation awareness

3a. AI Safety Barcelona

1. WhatsApp group communities: hackathons, discussions, social events
2. Weekly announcement: events, jobs, training and sometimes reading
3. Social meetups, organised talks for different audiences

www.aisafetybcn.org

3b. AI Safety Barcelona

1. Hosting a Hackathon hub
2. Publishing a career transition reflection with questions
3. Organising SPAR meetup
4. Exploring possibility of technical courses for people in Barcelona

www.aisafetybcn.org

Conclusion and Reflections

1. The path to AI Safety has ups and downs with lots of learning
2. Many people have inspired, helped and supported me along the way and I believe community is very important
3. There are many ways to have impact and to develop new skills (technical, governance, logistics, communications, recruiting)
4. If I can help, feel free to reach out. The next slides have some links I found helpful for opportunities

https://www.linkedin.com/in/niamhmaher75/

Helpful Links

- 80,000 Hours
- AISafety.com
- ML4Good.org
- BlueDot.org
- HUX AI internships
- ENAIS: get involved
- AI Safety Atlas

Fellowships

Paid Fellowships (+ many more)

ERA	Existential Risk Alliance
MATS	ML Alignment & Theory Scholars
Talos	Talos Fellowship
LASR	London AI Safety Research Labs
Pivotal	Pivotal Research Fellowship

Unpaid Fellowships/Internships (+ many more)

SPAR	Supervised Program for Alignment Research
MARS	Mentorship for Alignment Research Students
SOAR	Summer of Open AI Research